



Historic feat: Tanvi Sharma, the 16-year-old badminton player, made history at the 2025 US Open by becoming the youngest Indian to reach the final of a BWF World Tour event. PTI

(Tanvi and Radhika, who is her elder by three years), and I had hoped they might become national-level players. I never thought Tanvi would get to the level she has now," says Meena.

Unexpected start

Meena was a sportsperson herself, having played volleyball at the national level. After completing her postgraduation and later a PhD in physical education, she was determined that her daughters would play a sport. "I wanted them to play either tennis or cricket or badminton. Of the three, I liked badminton because when I was studying I had read stories about Saina and Sindhu. But when Radhika and Tanvi were children, they played all three sports," she says.

Hoshiarpur, their hometown on the NorthEastern border of Punjab with Himachal Pradesh, lacked quality sports infrastructure. When Radhika was nine, Meena took her to

the badminton court at the town's indoor stadium. There, she was faced with a new challenge – the lack of good coaches.

Instead of giving up, Meena chose to teach herself how to coach. "At that time I didn't think too much of it. I went through online videos and coaching manuals. I didn't have any great expectations of Radhika as a player so I thought even basic badminton knowledge would be enough. I learned the basic shuttle drills and I already knew how to give physical training, so that's what I started with," she says.

Tanvi would accompany them. "She was only about five then, so I couldn't leave Tanvi by herself. I had to bring her along. She'd come and try to get involved with the training. She was a bit of an accidental player in a way," says Meena. Radhika showed results first, winning medals at the State level and then a bronze at the Under-13 Indian National Ranking competition in 2016. That performance drew interest from the Pullela Gopichand Academy in Hyderabad. "They asked if I would be willing to let Radhika come to Hyderabad. I thought it was a great opportunity for her. But I couldn't let her go by herself because she was just 13 then. So I had to come with

her, and because Tanvi was even younger, I had to bring her to Hyderabad as well," Meena says.

From 2016 to 2020, Radhika trained with the hostel students at the Gopichand Academy. Meena took up a job at another badminton academy to support the family. At the time, Tanvi trained with beginners at Gopichand. Though she occasionally hit a few shuttles with Sindhu, there was little to suggest her future promise.

That changed during the COVID-19 pandemic. When the trio had to return to Hoshiarpur, Tanvi began to show signs of her potential – but not without uncertainty. "In 2021, when we had to move back to Hoshiarpur, I wasn't sure if I was going to continue to play badminton. I was good in studies as well, and we were under a lot of financial difficulties, which meant it was hard to train and also travel for competition. But we decided to try for one more year," says Tanvi.

Breakthrough year

In 2021, as a 12-year-old, Tanvi won her first national medal – a singles bronze in the U-15 category at the National Ranking Championships in Goa. She kept rising. In 2024, she claimed singles gold in both the U-15 and U-17 categories at the National Championships in Odisha. That same year, she was included in the Indian women's team for the Asian Team Championships, though she didn't get to play.

She remembers that tournament for another reason. "Sindhu *didi* was very good to me and her attitude was very good. I was only 15 at that time and I was injured so I didn't get a chance to play, but it was great just to be part of the Indian team and also to be alongside her. I talked to her, got to know her, and learned a lot just by watching her matches," she says.

By this point, Meena realised she could no longer offer the technical guidance Tanvi needed. "I was good enough to train her physically and mentally, but I couldn't provide the technical support she needed now